

Linking verbs

A linking verb links the subject of a sentence to a word or phrase that describes the subject. Linking verbs either relate to the senses (*feel, taste, smell, look, hear*) or to a state of existence (*be, become, appear, remain*). The most common linking verb is *be*.

subject → This linking verb is a past form of the verb *be*. → This adjective describes the state of mind of the rabbits.

The rabbits **were** frightened.

Identifying a linking verb

The simplest way to identify a linking verb is to substitute a form of *be* for the verb. If the resulting sentence makes sense, that verb is a linking verb. If it doesn't make sense, the verb is an action verb.

The chipmunk **looked** hungry. The chipmunk **looked** for berries.

Here, *looked* is a linking verb. Here, *looked* is an action verb.

substitute **is**

✓ The chipmunk **is** hungry. The chipmunk **is** for berries. ✗

The infinitive

The infinitive is the simplest form of a verb—the form that is used in dictionaries. It can be used on its own, but is almost always preceded by *to*. Unlike verbs, infinitives never change in form. They can be used as nouns, adjectives, or adverbs in a sentence.

The chipmunk **needed to eat**.

subject → This infinitive is acting like a noun, such as *food*, would act because it is the object of the sentence. →

He **found** a grasshopper **to eat**.

subject → This infinitive is acting like an adjective, because it is modifying the object of the sentence; it adds the information that the grasshopper is edible. →

A well-known exception to the **subject–verb–object** rule comes from the Christian marriage service: “With this ring, **I thee wed.**”

REAL WORLD

To boldly go or to go boldly?



Split infinitives occur when an adverb, such as *boldly*, is placed between the infinitive and the preceding *to*. It's preferable to keep the *to* next to the verb, but avoiding a split infinitive can make a sentence awkward. Split infinitives can be used sparingly for emphasis, to avoid confusion, or for a more natural reading order. A famous example is from the opening lines of the 1960s *Star Trek* television series: “To boldly go where no man has gone before.”

GLOSSARY

Intransitive verb A verb that does not require an object.

Linking verb A verb, such as *be*, that connects the subject of a sentence to a word or phrase—often an adjective—that describes the subject.

Object The noun or pronoun that is receiving the action of the verb.

Subject The noun or pronoun that is performing the action of the verb.

Transitive verb A verb that must be used with an object.